

Master Scheduling Playbook

A practical step-by-step guide for elementary, middle, and high school scheduling in Aeries

Who this is for

Principals, assistant principals, counselors, registrars, and district leaders who need a clear, repeatable process for building accurate school schedules. This version is written as a generic district resource so it can be reused every year.

Elementary	Middle School	High School
Build balanced class sections, protect intervention time, coordinate specialists, and prepare teacher/class rosters.	Balance required courses, electives, exploratory wheels, teams, advisory/flex periods, and student conflicts.	Align graduation requirements, A-G, pathways, AP/CTE, teacher loads, singletons, course requests, and counselor review.

The goal is simple: reduce late schedules, incorrect submissions, unscheduled students, teacher overloads, flex scheduling confusion, and last-minute rework.

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1. Start Here: The Scheduling Mindset

A master schedule is the instructional blueprint for the school. It determines where students go, which teachers teach which courses, how rooms are used, and whether interventions, electives, supports, and required courses can actually happen.

Plain-English rule

Do not treat the master schedule as a clerical task. It is an instructional leadership task that should be planned, reviewed, tested, and corrected before it is submitted.

- Build around student needs first, not adult convenience.
- Protect required courses, intervention blocks, and special programs before adding lower-priority options.
- Schedule singletons and hard-to-place courses early.
- Leave room for mobility, late enrollments, staffing changes, and corrections.
- Use reports and conflict lists before assuming the schedule is ready.

Common reasons schedules are late or incorrect

- Enrollment projections were not verified before building sections.
- Course requests were incomplete or entered late.
- Sections were created without checking teacher load, room capacity, or period balance.
- Flex/advisory/WIN periods were added after the fact instead of being planned from the beginning.
- Counselors or site leaders did not review unscheduled students and conflicts before final submission.

2. Recommended Annual Timeline

Timeframe	Primary Work	Tips & Tricks
Winter	Review staffing projections, enrollment estimates, course catalog, program needs, bell schedule, and prior-year problem areas.	Create a scheduling team early. Include principal/AP, counselors, registrar, SPED/ELD leads, and anyone who manages course requests.
Early Spring	Collect student course requests, confirm electives, identify singletons, define flex/intervention/advisory model, and verify required courses.	Do not wait for every request before planning. Build a draft based on projections, then revise.
Spring	Build sections, assign teachers and rooms, check teacher loads, check class-size targets, and run conflict analysis.	Schedule singletons first. Protect required services before lower-priority electives.
Late Spring / Early Summer	Run mass scheduling, review unscheduled students, adjust sections, resolve conflicts, and review with counselors.	Every unscheduled student is a signal. Find the pattern instead of fixing one student at a time.
Summer / Before School Starts	Finalize rosters, verify rooms, publish schedules according to local policy, and prepare first-week correction procedures.	Keep a controlled change log. Do not allow informal changes that bypass the scheduling team.

Red flag

If the first serious scheduling review happens right before school starts, the site is already late. The best schedules are tested and corrected before summer.

3. Before You Open Aeries Checklist

The most common scheduling mistakes happen before anyone clicks a scheduling button. Use this checklist first.

☐	Enrollment projections are reviewed by grade level.
☐	Staffing allocations are confirmed or clearly marked as tentative.
☐	Bell schedule is known, including lunch, flex, advisory, intervention, and block days.
☐	Room inventory is accurate, including specialized rooms such as science labs, gyms, music, CTE, SPED, and shared spaces.
☐	Course offerings are approved and inactive courses are identified.
☐	Graduation/A-G/pathway requirements are reviewed for secondary schools.
☐	Student course requests have a collection plan and deadline.
☐	Special programs are identified: SPED, ELD, intervention, honors/AP, CTE, dual enrollment, music, athletics, academies, pathways.
☐	Teacher credentials/preps/loads are reviewed.
☐	District submission expectations and local approval steps are known.
☐	A backup/export process is identified before major changes are made.

Tip

If a principal is new to scheduling, pair them with a counselor or registrar who understands how the site has historically built sections. Then verify that past practice still matches current student needs.

4. Elementary Scheduling Pathway

Elementary scheduling is usually less about individual student course requests and more about balanced classroom sections, specialist rotations, intervention blocks, and service delivery.

Step 1: Confirm enrollment by grade level

- Use current enrollment plus projected students.
- Plan for students who enroll late.
- Use class-size targets and local contract rules.
- Create a section count for each grade level.

Tip & trick

Do the quick math first: projected students divided by target class size = estimated sections. Then adjust for combination classes, program needs, and room availability.

Step 2: Build classroom sections

- Create one section per teacher/classroom.
- Assign teacher, room, grade level, term, and bell schedule as applicable.
- Leave room for mobility rather than filling every section to the maximum.

Step 3: Protect services and rotations

- Map ELD, SPED, intervention, counseling, PE, music, library, and other specialist rotations.
- Avoid placing intervention during core instruction when possible.
- Avoid creating a flex block that conflicts with services students are legally required to receive.

Step 4: Review for balance

- Check class sizes by grade.
- Balance student needs across sections.
- Review special program clusters so one teacher is not overloaded.
- Confirm teachers and rooms are correct.

Red flag

If one section is much larger or much more complex than the others, the schedule may look correct in Aeries but fail operationally.

Elementary final checks

☐	All grade-level sections created
☐	Teachers assigned
☐	Rooms assigned
☐	Specialist rotations documented

☐	Intervention/flex blocks protected
☐	SPED/ELD service conflicts reviewed
☐	Class sizes checked
☐	Rosters reviewed before school starts

5. Middle School Scheduling Pathway

Middle school scheduling combines required academic courses, PE, electives/exploratories, intervention, advisory, and often team-based structures. The biggest challenge is avoiding conflicts while keeping student schedules balanced.

Step 1: Build required courses first

- ELA, math, science, history/social science, PE, and required supports should be planned before electives.
- Determine the number of sections using course requests and projected enrollment.
- Protect special program sections, co-taught sections, and intervention periods early.

Step 2: Identify singletons and low-section courses

- Schedule band, advanced courses, specialized electives, and other single-section courses before high-volume electives.
- Avoid placing multiple singletons in the same period if students commonly need both.

Tip & trick

The fewer sections a course has, the earlier it should be placed. Singletons drive conflicts.

Step 3: Plan advisory/flex/intervention

- Decide whether flex is daily, weekly, rotating, or embedded in advisory.
- Decide if flex is graded, attendance-taking, intervention-only, enrichment, or mixed.
- Confirm how students will be assigned and moved.

Step 4: Run scheduling and analyze conflicts

- Run the scheduling process only after requests, sections, teachers, rooms, and periods are reasonably complete.
- Review unscheduled students and conflict reports.
- Look for patterns such as one elective blocking many students or not enough math sections in a period.

Middle school final checks

☐	Required courses available each grade
☐	Electives balanced
☐	Singletons reviewed
☐	Advisory/flex configured
☐	Teacher loads reviewed
☐	Rooms assigned
☐	Unscheduled students reviewed
☐	Counselors/site leaders reviewed conflicts

6. High School Scheduling Pathway

High school scheduling is the most complex because the schedule must satisfy graduation requirements, college eligibility, pathway completion, credit recovery, teacher credentialing, room constraints, and student choice.

Step 1: Start with requirements

- Confirm graduation requirements and local course sequences.
- Confirm A-G or college-readiness requirements if applicable.
- Identify credit recovery, intervention, ELD, SPED, CTE, AP/Honors, dual enrollment, academies, and pathway needs.

Step 2: Clean up course requests

- Verify requests are complete and realistic.
- Make sure students have alternates for electives.
- Check seniors and juniors first because errors may affect graduation or college eligibility.
- Use counselors to validate special cases before mass scheduling.

Step 3: Build sections based on demand

- Use request counts to estimate sections.
- Match sections to teacher availability, credentials, preps, and rooms.
- Schedule singletons and limited-access courses early.
- Avoid placing courses commonly taken together in the same period.

Tip & trick

For high school, every singleton should have a reason. Too many singletons create impossible schedules.

Step 4: Run, review, adjust, repeat

- Run mass scheduling.
- Review unscheduled students and conflict reports.
- Add/move sections based on patterns, not one-off complaints.
- Re-run and compare results until conflicts are manageable.

Step 5: Counselor validation

- Counselors review seniors, students with incomplete schedules, credit-deficient students, pathway students, SPED/ELD students, and students with unusual placements.
- Document intentional exceptions.

High school final checks

☐	Graduation requirements reviewed
☐	A-G/pathway needs reviewed
☐	Course requests complete

☐	Alternates entered
☐	Singletons reviewed
☐	Teacher preps and loads reviewed
☐	Room conflicts resolved
☐	Unscheduled students reviewed
☐	Seniors validated by counselors
☐	Final schedule approved by site leadership

7. Flex Scheduling Models

Flex scheduling can be powerful, but it must be designed intentionally. A flex period should have a purpose, ownership, attendance process, student assignment process, and review process.

Model	Best For	Watch Out For
WIN / Intervention Block	Targeted support, enrichment, reteaching, make-up work, student choice with guardrails.	Do not allow flex to become unstructured free time. Decide how students are assigned and tracked.
Advisory + Flex	SEL, academic check-ins, intervention, announcements, college/career activities.	Advisory teachers need expectations, rosters, and attendance procedures.
A/B Block	Longer instructional periods, labs, projects, fewer daily transitions.	Check course minutes, attendance rules, part-time programs, CTE, athletics, and shared staff.
Hybrid Traditional + Flex	Schools that need normal periods plus protected support time.	Flex must be placed so it does not collide with services or required courses.
Rotating Flex	Rotates to reduce missed instructional time.	Can confuse students and staff unless communication is excellent.

Flex planning questions

- Who owns the flex period?
- How is attendance taken?
- How are students assigned?
- Can students choose sessions?
- How are SPED/ELD/services protected?
- How will the site know flex is working?
- What happens when a student does not attend assigned intervention?

Red flag

If flex has no assignment process, no attendance process, and no accountability, it will create supervision and data problems.

8. Aeries Workflow Overview

Exact screens and names may vary by permissions and configuration. Use this sequence as the practical workflow for Aeries scheduling.

Phase	Aeries Work	Quality Check
Prepare	Review course table, terms, teachers, rooms, bell schedule, scheduling settings, and course request process.	Inactive courses removed or marked; teachers/rooms accurate; terms match site calendar.
Collect Requests	Enter or import course requests and alternates; verify required courses.	Run request count reports and missing request checks.
Build Sections	Create sections with course, term, period, teacher, room, max seats, and scheduling attributes.	Check period balance, teacher load, room conflicts, and class-size targets.
Schedule Students	Run mass scheduling / scheduling process.	Review unscheduled students, partial schedules, and conflict reports.
Revise	Add/move sections, adjust periods, update alternates, revise requests as needed.	Re-run until unscheduled students and conflicts are acceptable.
Finalize	Review rosters, publish according to local process, and prepare change procedure.	Principal/counselor approval and final checklist complete.

Backup habit

Before major schedule changes, export key reports or use your district-approved backup process. This prevents panic when a change creates unexpected results.

9. Troubleshooting Guide

Too many students are unscheduled

Likely causes: too few sections, singletons blocking students, missing alternates, required courses offered in too few periods, teacher/room restrictions. Fix: review conflict reports, identify patterns, add or move sections, then re-run scheduling.

One class is overloaded

Likely causes: max seats too high, too few alternate sections, student requests concentrated in one period. Fix: add sections, move section periods, adjust max seats, review demand.

Electives disappeared from schedules

Likely causes: required courses took priority, elective alternates missing, elective scheduled at same time as required singleton. Fix: check request priorities and conflicts, then add/move elective sections.

Teacher load looks wrong

Likely causes: sections assigned incorrectly, duplicate section, incorrect term, incorrect period, prep/contract issue. Fix: run teacher schedule report and compare to staffing plan.

Flex period conflicts with services

Likely causes: flex added after core/service schedules were built. Fix: protect service times first, then rebuild or adjust flex placement.

Rooms double-booked

Likely causes: room field missing, shared rooms not tracked, sections copied incorrectly. Fix: run room schedule/conflict report and correct assignments.

Seniors missing graduation courses

Likely causes: requests incomplete, sections full, course sequence error, transcript review incomplete. Fix: counselor audit of seniors before final schedule.

10. Final Readiness Checklists

Use these checklists before submitting or publishing schedules. Customize them for local timelines and approval steps.

Elementary checklist

☐	Enrollment verified by grade
☐	Sections created for each classroom
☐	Teacher and room assignments complete
☐	Specialist schedules aligned
☐	Intervention/flex time protected
☐	SPED/ELD/service conflicts reviewed
☐	Class sizes balanced
☐	Rosters reviewed
☐	First-week correction plan ready

Middle school checklist

☐	Required courses built
☐	Electives/exploratories built
☐	Singletons reviewed
☐	Advisory/flex configured
☐	Teams/grade levels balanced
☐	Teacher loads reviewed
☐	Rooms assigned
☐	Unscheduled students resolved or documented
☐	Counselor/admin review complete

High school checklist

☐	Graduation requirements reviewed
☐	Course requests complete
☐	Alternates entered
☐	A-G/pathway needs reviewed
☐	AP/CTE/singletons reviewed
☐	Teacher preps and loads checked
☐	Room conflicts resolved
☐	Mass scheduling complete
☐	Unscheduled student list reviewed
☐	Seniors and credit-deficient students reviewed
☐	Counselor validation complete
☐	Final leadership approval complete

Submission readiness checklist

☐	Schedule has been reviewed by principal/designee
☐	Counselor/registrar review completed where applicable
☐	Unscheduled students list is acceptable or documented
☐	Teacher assignment report reviewed
☐	Room report reviewed
☐	Class-size report reviewed
☐	Flex/advisory/intervention process documented
☐	Known exceptions documented
☐	Local district submission process completed

Final reminder

A good schedule is not perfect. A good schedule is reviewed, explainable, balanced, and ready for students and staff.